Apprehensions

A major apprehension concerning the IPL is that its riches will make playing for India somewhat less significant and correspondingly less appealing. Many say that a lot of Indian youngsters are content to earn substantial sums of money and lead a good life playing Twenty20. For me personally there is nothing that compares to playing for India, but it depends on the individual: is he prepared to put in the extra work required to play for his country, or is he satisfied with a couple of months of fame a year? Someone who is determined to play for his country will inevitably strive towards his goal, while those who aren't motivated enough to do so don't really deserve to don India colours.

Another concern is that the IPL might cause burn-out in Indian players. I don't quite agree with this proposition. While I am not debating the need to control the number of Twenty20 games played each year, putting all the blame for injuries on the IPL isn't always correct. The best players from all countries play the IPL and every country, at the moment, has a similar schedule. Given the amount of cricket being played around the world, injuries are now part of a cricketer's life. Australian players who haven't played the IPL have also been out for months injured, even though Australia has one of the best injury-management programmes in the world. Most international cricketers play with niggles and ultimately players themselves are the best judges of their bodies, and they have to be sensible and responsible when deciding whether to play or not.

Playing for the Mumbai Indians

I thoroughly enjoyed playing for the Mumbai Indians. Just after the IPL was launched in late 2007, Mukesh Ambani, the owner, told me that he would like me to captain the team and I readily agreed. As skipper, I made it very clear to my team-mates that all I wanted from them was total commitment on the field, and that's what we tried to do in my six seasons in the IPL.

It took some time to get used to how the auction worked. I was in Australia when the first one took place in February 2008 and had provided the management with a list of players I wanted for every position; in fact, I had provided multiple options. But the team we ended